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Kenny Davern

Kenny Davern is the leading jazz clarinetist of our day. Born in 1935, a native of Huntington, NY, his recording debut came at the age of 19 with Jack Teagarden. Career highlights include work with Buck Clayton, Red Allen and the Dukes of Dixieland. His soprano sax work was featured with Bob Wilber and Soprano Summit. Since 1979 he has toured with various quartets and recorded frequently, most recently in a string ensemble format with arrangements by Bob Haggart. Davern is a player of outstanding technical skills who combines classic jazz values with a modern harmonic approach.

Kenny was interviewed at Hamilton College on September 23, 1995 by Dr. Michael Woods.

MW: We are filming for Hamilton College and developing a jazz archive with America's greatest jazz musicians. We have with us a fabulous artist on clarinet, Kenny Davern.

KD: Hello, Michael.

MW: Tell us a little bit about the concert that you played last night. It had all the things in it that I try to teach my jazz class.

KD: Well—

MW: Let me give you what I mean. You played themes, you played backgrounds, each one of you got a chance to be featured, you played ensemble passages.

KD: Well, that's what the music is about basically. I think that as far as the tunes, I mean generally your basic song forms, 32 bars, what-have-you, from a period of music that probably from 1910 to about 1940, this phenomena occurred in the history of music that never had occurred before. Arias and stuff, maybe little songs. But never where the entire public has been able to sing a verse, and then probably the words to every stanza of the tune. And that never happened before or after. You know, like we're back to square A today where there is no song melodic form. If you take Andrew Lloyd Weber, nobody can sing past four bars of his music. That's it. I doubt if they could even sing four bars of it. But yeah, I mean so we're really dealing in a time capsule of music which no longer exists, which probably the greatest artists and practitioners of this kind of art form honed and crafted their trade.

MW: Would you even say that at that particular time that jazz was America's popular music? Or did that particular form that the music found itself in, how did it communicate to an audience better than some of the songs today?

KD: Well they could anticipate and memorize the melody and the lyrics, which is, as far as the period as far as I'm concerned, to the so-called originals that are being produced by everybody almost on the scene today. "I want to do my own things — I want to do my

original pieces" which is fine. I mean you could do that, I mean once I talked to Sonny Rollins about the fact that he played, I went to see him at the old Five Spot and he had taken "I Got Rhythm" and he played the melody at least a dozen times without changing any notes of the melody but changing it rhythmically to prove a point. There was a guy next to me sitting there, wearing shades at midnight in a darkened club, which was the de rigeur of the time, we're talking about the 50s, who said, "Why isn't he playing—" such-and-such, you know Charlie Parker's head or Dizzy Gillespie's head, or whoever's head on the tune? I said, "Well 'I Got Rhythm' is a far superior melody, you know, people can identify with that. And Sonny is doing a number on it so to speak." "Oh." You know what I mean? So I hope that answered that question.

MW: People need points of reference though.

KD: Yes, absolutely. In every walk of life.

MW: Tell us about the clarinet, because it's artists of your ilk that keep this instrument in the forefront.

KD: You think so? Some people might say the opposite. Some people might say we're helping to bury it. It's an instrument which could go the way of the oboe d'amour or the viola da gamba. It's a very difficult instrument. To quote Jerry Dodgion it was invented by two guys who didn't know each other. There's no rhyme nor reason for it. You have to be some kind of a sadist, masochist-sadist to continue on this instrument. It's not the voice of bebop, it's not the voice of today so to speak, even though there are more commercials on television I've noticed recently that use clarinets, you know, sort of in the background. Ever since the Benny Goodman-Chase Manhattan ad, you know. It has the most amount to offer of all the woodwinds in the sense that it has almost the same range as a violin. It has almost four and a half octaves, four octaves, you know which is a great deal of span, as opposed to two and a half of a saxophone, and whatever you can get out of a trumpet. You know and probably two and a half out of the oboe. And a little bit more out of the flute. But it's too difficult an instrument. And not everybody wants to devote themselves to that one thing, to do that. Because also it doesn't lend itself very well, as you've noticed, to so-called modern jazz. It just doesn't — it's not that kind of an instrument. It's not that kind of voice for the music. Whereas a saxophone is, most brass instruments are, and now they don't even call a pianist a "pianist" they call him a "keyboard player" which means —

MW: A synthesizer —

KD: Yes, exactly, whatever. So I don't know. But I grew up loving the instrument, that's all I can say. And whatever doubling I did on the way up it was always with the clarinet being the instrument that I was going to focus on from then on, you know, for the rest of my life, whether I made money or I didn't.

MW: But you have a very distinct voice on that instrument. You've taken that instrument past any generic conception into this elusive category that all musicians seek called "voice." And you have that.

KD: Thank you. That I think is a prerequisite for anybody doing anything, is to put their "John Hancock" you know, once you've seen that signature it's forever imprinted on your mind. And I think the only way you can ever establish yourself is to have something like the cookie cutter, according to that syndrome, is you must take it upon yourself to bite the bullet and say, for better or for worse, this is the way I sound. This is the sound that I make. And you must stand by it. And that's why this, you know "you're stealing my music," or "this is MY—" If you can make your own noise on the instrument and make your own sound which is instantly recognizable within let's say four bars, then you know, that's it. Then you ain't steal anybody's anything. You might be a composite or a storehouse or a bank, you know, a depository of all you've heard and all that's come before and all you've chosen to absorb. But once music is out there, you can do this. And I think that's the most important thing is to get what you've listened to, what impressed you most, what moved you most, and make it into your own thing. When Louis Armstrong died, Walter Cronkite when he was anchor on CBS had Dizzy Gillespie and Miles Davis and I think Buck Clayton and Bobby Hackett to name a few, this was in 1971, and he asked them well, "How did Louis Armstrong influence you?" So everybody, like Miles Davis says you know, "We'd all be digging ditches if it wasn't for Louis." And when he got to Bobby Hackett he said how did he influence you, and he says, "Well," he says, with that New England accent he says, "Well I spent half my life," he says, "stealing everything I could from him, and the other half covering it up." But that's it. I mean nobody, no one person can claim anything. Once it's out there, it becomes everybody's.

MW: It's public domain.

KD: Correct, it becomes music, and music is for everybody, for all.

MW: I wanted to ask you, you have a gift, and I'm going to kind of give a setting in which this gift manifests itself, and then I want you to talk about it. That is, not every musician, irregardless of their ability to be a great soloist or even to be a great arranger, has the gift to be a band leader, and you are a natural band leader. Talk about this.

KD: That's very interesting Mike, thank you. I say thank you because I enjoy being in control. I think that's number one, you have to enjoy being in control. You have to really believe that the guys that you're playing with will allow you to be in control and they won't go kibbitzing around. But I think you have to be an extrovert, which is either you're introvert or an extrovert, and you can't do it halfheartedly, otherwise it fails. And the ability to conceive the beginning, the natural beginning of a tune and how to end it, is

what it's probably about. You know, like how much time should you allow or allot a given piece? You know, for the most part though, like last night, well last night was not really a good example of what it was I can do as a leader because I was really not the leader I was more or less flung into it. When you have Scott and Warren and Ralph and the guys, they're all natural leaders. Each of them wants to be the leader but they're all being very reticent about taking the bull by the horns and doing it. But I prefer to work, really, and it's no reflection on their abilities and what they do, in as small a group as possible. A trio, quartet or quintet when it has a guitar added or whatever. Because then I can control the situation. And I think it's a need to control and not be controlled. Maybe that, you know, however — and also your presentation of how you talk to people.

MW: That's what I was going to ask you talk about too because you have a specific stage presence. And I want you to talk about this because you know this music is a combination when you play the blues there's some sorrow in there, but it can't be one hundred percent sorrow. And then of course when I see your stage demeanor there's some humor in there, but it's not trite, it's somewhere in the middle. Talk to us about that. Because you have, that's what I meant that you have a stage presence that, that mixture of humor and wit and sometimes even melancholy.

KD: Yes, you've got two things in there. You've got, in your statement, you've got blues, which is sad but then again blues can be like Lester Young, it can be frivolous, it can be cheerful, it can be medium-fast, medium-slow, very slow, dirge blues, uptempo blues. You know there are a lot of people who didn't know that the blues could be more than one you know like velchmats. You know, velchmatsix, which means for those of you who are out there in radioland, the weight of the world is on you. The blues is a natural thing as far as a feeling goes. Either some people can play and/or sing the blues, or they can't. And this is beyond racial things. I mean Marian Anderson when she sang "St. Louis Woman" with her "diamond ring" had about as much to do with blues as the man in the moon. But I'm deviating. Blues. The basis of all music as far as I'm concerned, at least this kind of music that we're talking about. When I was a kid in high school, we didn't know songs. We knew twelve bar blues. And we used to play it, like you said, sometimes like a dirge, like some kind of a heartfelt ballad, but some people you know if you play a ballad with a blues feel, then maybe they want to do a lindy. So you play the blues brighter, or into a real fast one, or play the fast blues. And maybe you threw in a song, you see, but for the most part that was my upbringing as a kid, playing blues. Now that's part one as I see it. The second part, humor. When I went to England, one of the first times I went over there, I discovered that if you were very serious with those people who were sitting there like this, with arms crossed. When I see people sitting there with arms crossed I know their defenses are up. Body language. And they're sitting there like

this. Let's see, let me see, who are you? So I think I said something to the tune of, "G'evenin' shore is nice to be here, hope you have a good time tonight" you know and I looked around and saw the light, and they fell on the floor because they were expecting something like, "Good evening, ladies and gentlemen, we're going to play now a number for your musical edification, we hope that you enjoy it." So I said, "Well here we are now folks, nice to see y'all out there havin' such a nice time." You know and that was the end of that.

MW: The Gomer Pyle routine?

KD: That's it, the Gomer Pyle routine, yeah. "Laverne'll leave the light on for ya." And they didn't expect that. And I think that you have to disarm your audience in order to just, okay, get rid of all this nonsense, and then maybe we can partake in a rapport. But if you feel that freeze or that chill, you can't really loosen up and play.

MW: Or it may take you three tunes to get through it.

KD: If it takes that long, Michael, I think it's the end of me. I'm shattered. It's got to come pretty quick, you know. You're right, though, it does sometimes I can't say it happens right away because you look out there and you don't really feel like bantering with them, you just want to play and see what we've got up on the bandstand because you just shook hands five minutes ago and you don't know if you're going to be able to do anything, before you want to make friends with the audience, or the musicians that matter.

MW: And it, isn't it funny sometimes how that you can play the exact same notes and play with the exact same energy, but if people are not ready or willing to receive what you're doing, the level of edification that they get is minuscule, or much lesser by comparison, then if they're free and open and looking forward to a positive experience.

KD: That's true, absolutely right. So the hard part is then, well, the same part of your question earlier about the blues, music is a form of entertainment. Maybe not the music but there should be, I mean the music could be deadly serious, witness those films that Louis Armstrong made in Denmark in 1932. I mean here you see this guy kind of like looking very southern relaxed style, and all of a sudden he picks up that horn and they pan in on him, and those eyes are like two pieces of steel. I leaped away from the screen when I first saw it because I said this guy, he is deadly in earnest. He may be kibbitzing up there, but those eyes are telling me, "Get out of my way, this is it." You've seen those films, Louis at Tivoly Gardens in Copenhagen. Incredible, incredible films. I think he is probably the biggest influence on my playing. I think he might have been the biggest influence. In fact, I don't think, I know he was the greatest influence on the entire scope of this century's music. And there hasn't been anything better than what it is he did on any given composition, the way he interpreted it. Some people would disagree with me, I mean I know in some parts of the world music began with John Coltrane. That to me I

think it sort of ended with John Coltrane, not began. There are some people, I heard on the radio the other night just going from airport to home or whatever, there was some guy talking about that he was going to go back to the roots of it all. And he was talking about people I never heard of. And then he said, well if you really want to go back to the roots, then we'll go back to John Coltrane, Miles Davis and Charlie Parker. I mean he just left out perhaps fifty years of wonderful stuff that helped form these guys into where they were, what they took it to finally. And that was very distressing.

MW: I wanted to ask you, you talked about Coltrane and of course his main innovation is what we call the sheets of sound, to the place where, and of course he began to go off into the free jazz movement and all that. What is happening now in jazz? Is there any movement now that you see in any way that is equal to any of the great artists or great movements that have shaped jazz in the past? Or is it at a standstill?

KD: I think you said it, it's at a standstill. It's perhaps in a state perhaps of decomposition because the other night I heard, again, airport to home and scan the airwaves, I heard a concert from I think it was either Carnegie Hall or Lincoln Center with Wynton Marsalis and they were playing the music of Jelly Roll Morton, which is what I cut my eyeteeth on so to speak when I was growing up. And I mean I really love that music. I could tell you the alternate takes you know, that kind of thing, that's how engrained and how much I loved Jelly Roll's music as a kid and I still do. And I heard them, when I say "them" that whole group of guys who formed that organization who are like what would you call them, part of the repertory company, take that music and actually decimate it to the point where I was outraged that they should play this music so badly and, even if they read the notes they were being played without really the true passion that the music had, and the musicianship was noticeably inferior to the original. And if you can't do it as good as the original, do it different than, but don't try to do it the same way and have it fall short of the mark, you see. And I just said they're making a travesty of the music that I grew up and loved, you know. The same as using alternate takes as — supposing you were a kid and you never heard this stuff. It always takes some recording that goes WHAM, that gives you the emotional hook so to speak, where you bite, and you say that's it, this music is IT. And it comes at different times. Hopefully it comes at an earlier age, then you have much more time to develop and you know to work things out. But I've heard, even Louis Armstrong's second and third takes, which were not the ones that the artist intended to be issued, and being the artist is now deceased and has no representation of his own music, people seem to feel free that they can take a second or third or what they call alternative/alternate take, and use it as the one that was set up as the standard. The one that grabbed me. The one that said when I hear this played, this song played, that's the definitive version of it. It will never be better than that. And that's what I love about

this particular thing. And then they play one that was with a couple of flubs a couple of goofs and which is not bad, but, it didn't have exact placement in the articulation of that particular, those notes. And to make up this masterpiece that deservedly belongs to be raved about, but, they'd go and they'd decimate that too by a take that wouldn't grab the young kid that let's say I was, today coming along, and it wouldn't grab him, it wouldn't send out the message that that original one did.

MW: Let me ask you something on this. And is that all about money and just selling records?

KD: Yes and no. I think a lot of it is ignorance. I just think somebody's out there, you know some of those DJs who can't pronounce even half the names of the sidemen correctly, and you should hear, you've probably heard some of that one, you know you just go crazy, what's this guy doing. No I think some of those people just don't know the difference. Or they themselves have not been hooked on a particular tune, or version rather, not tune. I think yes is a way it might be that they'll try to capitalize on alternate takes and stuff. But if you don't know the original take, the alternate take wouldn't make any difference to you. So I don't think money is really the thing. Because first of all, the majority of people who have the records started collecting them when they were on 78s, as I did. And then they went to LP. Then you grabbed them in LP form. And then from LP or EP, and then now it's CD. And I find myself so almost befuddled when I walk into a large record store and I cannot, I see like ten different versions I mean of the same piece, on different labels and pirated labels and I don't know which one to buy because I don't know what it's going to sound like. What's the transfer like, and stuff like that. And if you grow up listening to the originals as they were issued, you know, I'm not talking the time when they were issued, but on the original intent, like a wind up phonograph and stuff like that, and you hear the way they sound, that stays with you. It really gets you here. If, then hear how it's been convoluted from generation to generation, until you wonder what did this thing really sound like, you know. And that's something that deserves some studying, really.

MW: I wanted to ask you something else about that. You know music, whereas we know that it's communication, can also be sonic culture.

KD: Sonic?

MW: Sonic.

KD: Sonic culture.

MW: And the reason you're saying something and I want you to elaborate on it a little bit more, and that is, sometimes when I hear an artist, when I hear Louis Armstrong records and when I hear Charlie Parker records, I get the feeling that these players were not just playing something because they had just learned a new scale or learned a new chord, but they were saying something because they really meant it and that was communicating to

people who agreed, by their applause and by the enthusiasm in which they accepted these artists.

KD: Yeah.

MW: What, where is that happening today? Are we doing it today or what, if that's not happening, how can we get it? How can we jump start it?

KD: The tragedy here I think is we are being, we are in the wrong place at the wrong time in the sense that we wouldn't have this problem if we were born say, for myself 20 years earlier than I was born. You, a great deal more. Because we're witnessing the end of music as we love it I think. I think physically, one man with a synthesizer can produce four times the amount of volume in a given space, like vis a vis a ballroom, that in 1938 it took 16 men, well trained, practicing bunnies and section rehearsals and okay fellas, to get that kind of intensity and volume into a ballroom, which, because all kids are the same whether it was 1938 or 1998. They all really are morons, you know they really are. But it just so happens the music — that the intensity of the working up, and the pitch of music then, I think was superior to let's say the same amount of intensity given off in a rock concert. Well actually there's more intensity given off in a rock concert, but it's a similar kind of frenzy. Kids need to congregate and do tribal things, you know, tribal rituals, like "The Rite of Spring," sacrifice of life and stuff. That's what it all is, it really is. And they have to congregate together and somehow or other, and maybe it's like some primordial thing where there's a sense of smell. But the same kids today, as was supposedly back in '38 or '28 or whenever you talk about them, they're the same people, the same mentality, and very little has changed as you can tell. But what has changed, and that's the sad part back to what you asked before, is that the means of communication, vis a vis the instruments, although there are many, many people out there playing instruments, have no place to go with them. And to be usurped by one man and his synthesizer, and there are no more clubs, a few of them but not very many, with a variety of music. That's the other thing, variety. There's no variety out there. There's either very very bad traditional, or very very bad ultra modern, whatever that means, both of which will bore you to tears, even in small doses. So the emotional impact of a single instrumentalist going out there and doing his thing is a rare phenomenon. And I hate to say it, I mean I hate to see it vanish but it's very possible with the values of the world today as we know it, to see this entire western idea of culture, you know from Bach on to the present day, go bye-bye.

MW: Fall prey to Blockbuster Video and a bag of microwave popcorn?

KD: Sure, that's right, and a floppy disc. It's very possible.

MW: I have a theory. I want you to expound on this. I don't think that's going to happen, you know why? I think the pendulum, no matter how negative we think, can only swing so far

before young people of their own volition sit down one day, go to a library, pick up a Charlie Parker record and now you've got to let them think it's their discovery, "I've discovered Charlie Parker." When they think it's their discovery and they think it's their peer group way of being hip, then I think quality will kind of reinvent itself and become part of the scenario like you said.

KD: Well I hope that this is true, not only for your sake, but for all of our sakes, and for people who live music and practitioners and artists, you know who have come to the height of a Charlie Parker phenomenon. But that type of phenomenon needs to be nurtured in a culture that digs what it is doing. And just, although jazz music was always a minor, I mean a subculture, a minor percentage of the population really knew — I mean the so-called jazz age was not the jazz age at all. Big bands were not jazz music. Great jazz soloists were in those bands but those were not, I don't care who wrote the charts. Thus the jam session was born. A band would come into town and the guys were so drugged, night after night after night playing SOS on the book, and they would find these little horns in the clubs and test their mettle against each other by playing, you know. And that is the part that really is missing and may remain missing forever. Because the stuff, the clubs, the environment it spawned guys who could play like Roy Eldridge's going against this guy and that guy, and Hawkins against a Webster, and all these different people. That doesn't exist anymore. So where are they going to do this? Even though jazz, like I said before, is an underground and always was, a very small percentage of the population ever really got it. Period. And what you're saying is maybe some guy who is like the leader of his peer group, says "listen to that." Well is he rediscovering, is he rediscovering Brahms or is he rediscovering Offenbach. I mean I don't see what you mean, it's a very obscure or obtuse correlation but it does, is, well maybe he'll discover Rudy Weidoft instead of Charlie Parker. See now that could be the rub. You see what I'm saying?

MW: Yeah, I do see what you're saying.

KD: Like Bach was overlooked for a hundred years until Mendelssohn.

MW: Mendelssohn, um humm.

KD: Found his music and brought it to the public, at the Leipsig Gewand haus. Prior to that his music was buried and forgotten. His sons' music was much more popular than the old man's music. So today would you go, all right, I think I've belabored that point.

MW: Well listen, I know that you all are going to perform yet again tonight and I thought that the performance that you did last night was some of my students were there from my History of Jazz class, and I thought it was just simply a clinic, everything that I've told them about you guys did.

KD: That's lovely to hear. I mean that's nice. It makes us feel good that we lived up to your expectations of what you wanted them to experience. And that's what music is really, isn't it Mike? It's an experience. It's an emotional experience like reading or looking at a painting. And either you have a penchant for picking up on that, or you don't. I mean you either get an emotional experience from it or you don't.

MW: I was going to talk to you about that too. You talk about an emotional experience and you also talk, you used before the word "passion." You spoke on Louis Armstrong and you talked about passion. And the thing I would like to see and I would like you to talk about this that I'd like to see come back even more so in jazz, is passion being pushed to the forefront, even more so than technique.

KD: Technique.

MW: You've got to have some though.

KD: Technique is only good enough to execute an idea. If you have no ideas, then technique by itself is not music.

MW: It's an etude.

KD: It's not even that. It's not as good as that. An etude at least has form and shape. But technique, how many notes you can cram into a bar is totally meaningless. One note, well placed at the right time with the right intensity, is worth more than a thousand notes played at a velocity that's like fancy footwork, it's dazzling. It's good for children. Children like to be dazzled. But mature people don't want to be dazzled, only unless it's to show a point or say, see I can do that too. Yeah, but technique is really nothing more than the execution of an idea. If you have no ideas, then you're just an array of cunning stunts.

MW: How does a musician translate human experience into sound, to get those ideas? Or how do you do it?

KD: Well, I'm a composite of everything I've heard. A sponge. We're all sponges, all humanity is a sponge. Take a little from this guy, a little from — ah it's beautiful, okay. What it boils down to is can you sing through your horn? Can you sing? Can you sustain a melody and make it beautiful without all the gibberish and nonsense and trying to show everybody how many notes you can play around a melodic theme. I mean can you just state, simply, the bare essentials of a melody and make it convincing? Strip it to its bare essence. And Charlie Parker knew how to do that, and Louis Armstrong knew how to do that, to name a few or a couple. So I don't know, there are so many wonderful musicians. I mean if you hear Bix Beiderbecke play, I mean he played magnificently, hear Frankie Trumbauer play. There should be a musical reevaluation of what his influence was, because he — Lester Young and Buddy Tate and Eddie Barefield, and also Don Byas. All these guys I knew, all tipped their caps to Frank Trumbauer who was in Kansas City

at the time. He operated out of St. Louis and Kansas City at the Muehlebach Hotel. This goes to him. This is when Coleman Hawkins was still slap-tonguing, he was bending and slurring notes and they all acknowledge him as the probably most influential. Prez took his sound from Frankie Trumbauer's C melody saxophone.

MW: Am I correct in saying that by nature, the C sax spoke a little softer than the tenor or alto?

KD: Absolutely. I've played C sax as you call it, the C melody saxophone. But it is a C tenor. If you look at the charts, you know the stuff from contra bass saxophone, bass saxophone to, then it says baritone saxophone, E flat, then B flat, then tenor, B flat tenor and then just above, it tenor in C melody, and then E flat alto, F mezzo saxophone, etc. However there are two ways of playing that instrument, you can either use an alto mouthpiece or a very small old fashioned Otto Link tenor mouthpiece. With that if you use it, the chambers are the same as a C melody, you know. An alto mouthpiece will get a Prez-like sound, which Prez's first instrument was a C melody, and if you use the old fashioned Link mouthpieces like Ben Webster used to use, you get this Hawkins type sound, vis a vis the Ramblers when Hawking recorded in Holland before the second World War with the Dutch group called The Ramblers, where he made his most rhapsodic, romantic statements with that band, you've heard them, you know, "Mitch's Dream" and things like that. Wonderful, wonderful tracks. That will come out on the C melody. It's a very versatile instrument that way. But, once again I was talking to Sonny Rollins about it years ago, and it has no carrying power. It is truly, I mean you may sit there and it's very comfortable to play and you may love it, you know you get all kinds of nice things and hold it up this way. It doesn't carry. And that's probably why it went out of popularity. Also the key is not really conducive to, unless you like to play in C sharp and F sharp and D and G flat, and things like that.

MW: Those are some really tasty insights. And another thing that you've talked about, you've talked about how one player influences another. That I think is important. Do you know of players that you've influenced?

KD: Yeah, but the thing is this, Mike, I mean let's put it this way. There are people who have very strong — if you're stylistically strong, there's a very good possibility you may have no followers and influence no one because you're unique in that way. I mean unless you are truly a revolutionary, vis a vis Charlie Parker, vis a vis Louis Armstrong. But the difference between Louis and Charlie Parker was that everyone that tried to play like Louis Armstrong, you could take 20 guys and they all sounded different. Even like I think Rex Stewart told me. Dressed like Louis. Walked like Louis. Tried to play like Louis. He still sounded like Rex Stewart. You name him. Roy always thought well this is another influence, but I mean all these different people, Doc Cheatham, they all, Harry

James, really very diversified cast of characters all claimed that they were influenced by Louis Armstrong but they all sounded so different and unique in their own way. Fine. Charlie Parker, however, everyone that ever tried to be influenced by Charlie Parker, ended up by sounding like him, to the point where I heard some early Sonny Stitt recordings, I couldn't tell the difference, I really said — what's this, Parker I haven't heard? And it turned out it was Sonny Stitt. Of course I'd never heard it by Charlie Parker, because it was Sonny Stitt. So is this good or bad? I mean to be able to emulate somebody but be stuck in their grip so to speak is not good. Then you never get your voice. But to emulate somebody and come out with your own little thing involved with it, is another ball game again.

MW: To emulate to the point just of discovery.

KD: Correct. But not mockery or whatever the word is.

MW: Like the Elvis impersonators.

KD: That's macabre. Don't laugh. It's just as macabre in jazz life too, to see all these Charlie Parker clones come out. Did you ever hear of the guys who try to emulate Louis where they, Armstrong, where they really fail is when they try to do the vocalizations. Then it becomes a travesty, like the Elvis. Because that's where they fail. Unless they just use their own natural voice. I mean if you want to quote that, like Ethel Waters did, "I Can't Give You Anything But Love, Baby," but she actually does scat Louis' chorus, she'd get away with it. Why? Because she was one of the founding — without her there'd be no female vocalists in the big bands. She set the whole stage from whence they all came. Whether you had a Mildred Bailey or a Billie Holiday or you name them. They all came out of Ethel Waters. She was THE grand dame of how the female vocalist should sound. Does that make sense?

MW: Yes it makes a lot of sense. We are going to have to move here, because I know that we've got to wrap up this interview, but I've enjoyed talking to you. You've given us some marvelous insights. Say something to our young people about going into this music, if they find themselves as music majors in universities now. What are they going to have to face? And how to face it?

KD: A lack — these very poor guys are going to find that you have no place to practice your art and you're going to have to create it. And I don't know if there is enough initiative to create it. That after you've learned certain things, how are you going to, and where are you going to release this and test your mettle and test your knowledge and test your feelings? Where are you going to display this? If you have no place to display this, then it becomes nothing more than a phonograph memory, which is very sad I know. I'm not exactly a bundle of enthusiasm when it comes to mapping out what would be a future for anyone that comes and studies music seriously, but, if you study music seriously, you

will have gained something personally inside. Whether or not you ever become a practitioner or you know just a part time practitioner, or whatever. It doesn't matter. The fact is you will have gained something that will be something that you can keep within your self lifelong if it grabs you. And that's it. I mean there's no other way I can think of. I can't say, "Oh it's a great life out there — a wonderful field — just millions of opportunities — just graduate and a hand will pick you up and snap you into a band and you'll go on the road and see the world."

MW: It's like, what's wrong with this picture?

KD: End.

MW: Thank you very much.